More than high level interactions, day-to-day diplomatic activity deserves a consistent priority. India already devotes a considerable share of its diplomatic resources to the neighbourhood: the Ministry of External Affairs has four specific divisions dedicated to bilateral diplomatic relations with neighbours and two further divisions working on regional multilateral institutions. Still, more could be done. While India has a handful of consulates in its neighbours, increasing its diplomatic footprint in Nepal, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka to improve commercial and public diplomacy would be a natural progression of India's Neighbourhood First policy.

One way in which the neighbourhood is often overlooked by India is in terms of adequate intellectual capacity, including among the broader strategic community outside government. In addition to improving language capabilities (such as in Sinhala, Bhutanese, and Dhivehi) and engaging in Bengali, Tamil, and Nepali, a better understanding of the region by India will require greater scholarship on these countries' history, politics, and economics. While India has recently been devoting resources to develop a better understanding of China, including through Indian government-backed China studies centres, it could also consider encouraging country-specific policy centres for each of its neighbours. Such centres could also become valuable intellectual bridges between the policy communities of India and its regional partners.

Beyond bilateral relations, India has in recent years been forced to rethink its approach to regional institutions. For several decades, India's efforts were focused on the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC). Because of both Indian and Pakistani concerns about the organization being used against them, SAARC focused on less controversial issues. India did not want to be hemmed in by the organization while Pakistan harboured its own suspicions. There have been some benefits, including technical cooperation—for example on climate conditions—and the South Asia University in New Delhi. One way of reviving SAARC was to not always hold it to consensus, as had been past practice. A concrete example of this was the SAARC Satellite proposed by India in 2014 which was to include telecommunications, disaster